PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Land Rover Discovery Series I

1989–1998 · Discovery 1 · 200Tdi · 300Tdi · 3.9 / 4.0 V8

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Sills, floors and inner wings**
  On LandyZone the standard buying advice is a list of rust: sills, rear floor, boot floor, inner wings, then everything else. Three-doors are reported to be worse. Lift the carpets, check the boot floor and its support strap, and push on the sills where the body mounts sit.
- [ ] **Rear chassis and body mounts**
  Look at the mounts where the large rear crossmember meets the chassis rails, the rearmost body mounts and the box sections around the fuel tank. Galvanised replacement chassis exist, which tells you how often the originals give up.
- [ ] **Sunroofs and headlining**
  Most Disco 1s have two sunroofs, and they leak around the plastic surround and through split drain tubes. A sagging or stained headlining and wet carpets are the clues. A LandyZone member points to the 1998 Anniversary model as a way to dodge the sunroofs, and the US XD was built without them.
- [ ] **Swivels and front end**
  Pitted swivel balls weep oil and chew seals; look for oil on the inside of the front wheels. Check the swivel ball part number too: owners report the superseded FTC5366 ball doesn't machine-match the earlier FRC7065.
- [ ] **Driveline backlash (manual Tdi)**
  A jerky take-off on a manual 300Tdi is often the rear propshaft's rubber coupler or worn splines. With the centre diff locked, turn the front and rear props by hand in opposite directions; there should be only a little movement.
- [ ] **V8 cooling and idle**
  Overheating V8s and Tdis can be an airlock, a failed cap or a head gasket. Bleed and test before condemning the engine. On 14CUX trucks, a hunting or high idle points at the idle air control valve or a vacuum leak.
- [ ] **300Tdi timing belt**
  Like the Defender, the 300Tdi should have the revised timing-belt kit (Land Rover STC4096L-type) fitted. Ask for proof.
- [ ] **Japanese imports**
  Japanese-market re-imports are popular because they rot less, but LandyZone members note they're generally automatics and usually have sunroofs.

YEARS TO KNOW

1994	SWEET SPOT	Facelift: 300Tdi, 3.9 V8, stronger R380 manual, new dash with airbags. Guides call the 300Tdi the sensible choice, and it commands a premium over the V8

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **Driver airbag can deploy from overheating rotary coupler**
  1994–1998 · NHTSA 98V040000
- [ ] **Plastic fuel tank stress cracks**
  1994–1997 · NHTSA 04V203000
- [ ] **Right front door may not latch fully**
  1995–1996 · NHTSA 96V247000
- [ ] **Driveshaft nuts replaced with wrong size at port**
  1995 · NHTSA 95V099000
- [ ] **Replacement rear driveshaft coupling (service part)**
  1995–1998 · NHTSA 12E010000

- [ ] **200Tdi or 300Tdi?**
  The 200Tdi has two V-belts and an aluminium strengthener between block and sump; on the 200Tdi Discovery the injection pump sits high on the right and the turbo low on the left. The 300Tdi has one serpentine belt, no strengthener and a piston-type vacuum pump.
- [ ] **14CUX or GEMS V8**
  US 1994–95 trucks have the 3.9 V8 with Lucas 14CUX injection; 1996–98 trucks have the GEMS-managed '4.0' (still 3,946 cc) with OBD-II.
- [ ] **Japanese imports**
  Popular because they rot less, but LandyZone members note they're generally automatics with sunroofs. Honda also sold a badge-engineered Disco 1 in Japan as the Crossroad.
- [ ] **Special editions**
  Camel Trophy trucks, the US XD (250 in AA Yellow) and UK Safari, Goodwood and Horse and Hound editions all exist; check trim and paint against the build record.
- [ ] **Heritage certificate**
  The British Motor Museum's Heritage Certificates cover Land Rovers from 1948 on and record build date, engine number, colour and equipment.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/land-rover/discovery-1/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks